

The future of professional social networking

Read on to find out how corporate social media will change in the future.

Infancia Cardozo
infancia.cardozo@thinkdigit.com

Before the growth of online networking this past decade, personal networking was the only way to expand your horizons. Rubbing elbows, attending public meetings and associating with strategic people used to be one of the easiest ways to take you to your chosen destination and grow bigger in your chosen profession.

Skip to the future: you walk into a meeting, subway station or airplane and see profile information about other people in the area, depending on privacy settings (of course!) – all made possible by mobile internet connectivity. You can set filters according to your criteria and if you find someone interesting who shares your interests, you can look up their profile and contact them.

Or consider this. You go to a party and see the picture and first name of everyone there with an iPhone – although they'd be strangers, you already share common ground with them! You could take the next step and initiate what could go on to be a long-lasting professional relationship. Once mutual friendship is established, you could stay updated and follow the progress of those within your circle of fellow professionals. This way, entrepreneurs could meet investors or bankers. In case you doubt the extent to which personal interaction has subsided in the recent past, ask an average professional when was the last time they went to the bank and met the cashier to draw some cash for buying that new cell phone. With online transactions

and services such as credit/debit cards, automated teller machines seem to have obviated the need for personal interaction. You simply need to log in to your online banking account and transfer money via the transaction of your choice.

Current trends

The current scenario is a harbinger of things to come. Trends are in and out quicker than the seasons change. Currently though, we can see an inclination towards the following:

► **Collective knowledge sharing:** This is potent and powerful, and social media is making this knowledge easier to spread. LinkedIn's industry-specific forums are gaining popularity by the day, a fact that is evident in its growing numbers.

Twitter is another growing avenue for sharing of knowledge. Although internet users have the inclination, either due to lack of time or sheer laziness, more and more of them “consult” friends on networks such as Twitter for quick opinions, and reviews on choices they need to make. The key advantage such networks offer is the quick turn around time. In most cases, feedback and opinion is often instantaneous. This has the added benefit of cutting costs on surveys and polls.

► **Social gaming and branding:** Brand integrations with existing gaming platforms, as well as brands creating specific games to promote themselves is now as common as they get. Web sites such as FourSquare enable you to cash in on your check-ins by giving you

